Most Massive Woman Wins

By Madeline George

SCENE: The play takes place in a liposuction clinic waiting room.

- It is important the play be established as humorous from the outset.
- A great deal of the 'dialogue' is directed out to the audience; they are often able to pick up on each others' thoughts without speaking straight at one another.
- The chants are genuine hopscotch, jumprope and handclap rhymes from my own childhood and other children in Amherst, Massachusetts.
- We used blocking inspired by children's games: London Bridge and Mulberry Bush for the scoliosis check, Red Rover for the thesis defense, Musical Chairs for Carly's job interviews.

Monologue Notes
- Carly talks hard and fast and never gets sentimental, but she loves her kid.
-Sabine is extremely hard on herself and never gives herself a break; instead of getting sad she always gets angry, right through to the very last line
-Rennie is perpetually panicked and jumpy; it's as if there's nothing holding her down to the floor. She laughs a lot to disguise her fear.
-Cel is not crazy. Her monologue is driven by her own need to tell her story. She does not relive the moment of her self-immolation, she tells us about it (this is important). Realization and catharsis come at the very end of the monologue, not before.

AT RISE: The light is bright and sterile. SABINE, CEL, CARLY and RENNIE are seated on the chairs. For several minutes they stare at their magazines, fidget, cough, cross and recross their legs and flip magazine pages in an otherwordly, choreographed little dance.

INTRODUCTION

It takes courage to face a world where fat is equated with personal failure, lack of self-control, and lack of femininity. As four women in a liposuction clinic share their stories and childhood memories, they strive for a new understanding of beauty. Body image affects us all, and The Most Massive Woman Wins by Madeline George speaks to our closeted inadequacies and how we punish ourselves for our "imperfections."

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CARLY: It starts like a tidal wave under your feet and grows and grows until you forget your name and the people you love and all you know is you have to eat.

CARLY: You sneak out of bed, you don't think he hears you, you run down the stairs to where you hid the Sugar Smacks behind the TV; you're alone at last and you're eating great fistfuls, hand over hand. It tastes like everything you never had.

CARLY: You eat and you eat until you can't fit another bite into your body, you're bloated, drowned from the inside out.

SABINE: A beached whale, you can't move an inch.

CEL: You're done.

SABINE: You're done for.

SABINE: Regain control.

CARLY: And you go back to doing what you were doing before.

SABINE: But you know you did it.

CARLY: It's your fault - you lost control.

CEL: You know better than that.

SABINE: SO it's time to make an adult decision.

CARLY: *[Smacks her awn butt.]* Throw out the evidence.

RENNIE: You think of every sin in your past

CEL: Every slice of pie

CARLY: Every french fry

SABINE: Every chocolate croissant

SABINE: You are responsible for your own behaviour.

RENNIE: You are guilty.

CARLY: The other night my boyfriend goes to me, he's spread eagle on the couch giving his gut some air watching Monday Night Football and during the commercial he goes, "We don't have steak anymore. How come is it we never have steak?" I'm about to say, "You want steak, buy steak. Take it out a your paycheck, if you want steak so bad," but then he says to me, like, right in the same breath he goes, "What am I

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saying? You're too fat for steak. Last thing you need is fatty red meat." Just like that, then he tips back his beer and the conversation's over.

It's like I can't tell him off. Then later he leaves me this liposuction ad he clipped from the classifieds on my bedside table with a signed blank check. Is the guy subtle or what? You think it doesn't make me sick? What's the matter with me that I can't tell Frank Nowak where to stick it? I'm a weenie, that's what. A big fat wimp. How am I supposed to look my own kid in the face?

[Lights shift, whistle.]

CARLY: What about benefits?

RENNIE: *[Strongly emphasizing the 'Mizz.']* We haven't yet decided if this is an appropriate job for you, Ms.

CARLY: Kinski.

RENNIE: Let's hold off our discussion of fine points and sundries until we are able to come to a full understanding.

CARLY: Sure thing, sir. *[Whistle.]*

SABINE: Let me be frank, Ms.

CARLY: Kinski.

SABINE: I don't think you have fully considered the physical taxation that is put on a person in this line of work.

CARLY: Sir, I been in food service all my life.

SABINE: The waitstaff here are part of our family. And because of the extreme demands placed on their persons I demand that every member of the family be in peak physical condition.

CARLY: Alls I'm saying sir is I can do this job and I just wanna know about the benefits you - *[Whistle]*

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CEL: *[Overlapping.]* I'm afraid I'm not fully getting through to you, Ms.

CARLY: Kinski, Kinski.

CEL: Allow me to speak as plainly as possible. I really don't think the restaurant can use a woman of your stature at this time. Please don't take this personally, but with the aesthetic atmosphere I am trying to cultivate there are certain, hmmm, discrepancies that cannot be tolerated.

CARLY: I been trying to tell you *[Whistle.]*

RENNIE: *[Cutting in.]* Most of the girls I hire are eighteen, nineteen years old. *[Whistle.]*

SABINE: They haven't been through what you've been through I'm sure. *[Whistle.]*

CEL: I hope you won't be unduly upset by this. *[Whistle.]*

RENNIE: Not everything can be fair in this world, I'm afraid.

[Lights shift, hospital gowns fly in, the women stand behind them and undress during the next exchange, then put the gowns on.]

CARLY: My mama was - she used to say "plump and juicy.»

RENNIE: My mother said for big girls like me it was ugly to let people see the stuff you were made of. Especially legs and shoulders and the inside of your mouth.

SABINE: Our mothers all taught us the same thing.

CARLY: Hush up, Carly girl.

SABINE: Sit still till we get to grandma's and mama'll give you a cookie.

CEL: If you're good you can lick the bowl.

CARLY: Do you kiss your mother with that mouth?

RENNIE: Sit up straight and eat only what you're offered.

SABINE: Children are starving in Denmark.

CEL: Eat your peas.

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SABINE: Or was it Detroit?

CARLY: Open wide!

RENNIE: What's the matter, don't you feel well?

CARLY: What's wrong, don't you want dessert?

SABINE: Here, darling, have some of mama's home baked cherry pie.

CEL: Chicken-fried steak.

RENNIE: Chocolate mousse. *[They all laugh and "mmm" in agreement.]*

CARLY: Baby, you are so be-yoo-tiful, just like a calendar girl with those big brown eyes and that beautiful skin!

RENNIE: Why did everyone always tell me I had beautiful skin?

CARLY: And babes, someday you'll thank me for letting you put on that extra padding. When your airplane crashes on the highest peak of the Himalayas all those skinny passengers are gonna starve to death seven ways till Sunday and you will survive for months and months, living only off what you have stored in your tush.

SABINE: Mama's always right. You just wait.

[RENNIE, CEL *and* SABINE *return to their corners to sit, lights up on* CARLY *in the center.]*

CARLY: No my mama was not always right. No, you should a seen her when he'd come home nights, the whole place'd get quiet like the grave, I swear, she'd be pussyfootin' around him jumping like a sick kitten every time he made a move... all you could hear was him chewing with his mouth open and his silverware hitting the plastic plate.

It's too late for my mama, it's too late for me now. But the day my kid was born I made it a promise that she was gonna know who she was. No one was gonna walk all over my kid. No one was gonna give her a goddamned blank check.

Then the other day I come home from work and there she is, my stupid kid, sitting on the bathroom floor, leaning against the tub, and her long blonde hair is dyed pitch

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black, I swear, black as tar, and it's dripping black rivers all down her face and her neck... I could have killed her right then and there, I wanted to knock her head off of her skinny little neck.

Instead of killing her I say, Jesus Christ, what the hell did you do to your hair, and she's crying and choking and she goes, Ma! and points at the counter. I looked and I swear I thought I was going to toss my cookies. She has got one of these EPT plus pregnancy tests laid out there, you know, the little stick kind? Pink, pregnant, white, not pregnant... there's that little stick leaning up against the box it came in and the end is as bright pink as an Easter egg, pink like a baby's butt is pink. Talk about history repeating itself. Suddenly I'm sixteen again with that sinking feeling in my stomach looking at the little test tube, holding it up against the light bulb in the upstairs closet....

So I'm trying to figure out what exactly the black hair has got to do with the pink stick. I say, Is that or is that not an EPT plus pregnancy test? and she nods, so I say, Is that or is that not a pink stick you got there? and she says, It's pink. I say, So you're pregnant, so you dyed your hair black? She starts sobbing and wailing and she goes, I knew you wouldn't understand, you never understand anything about me! She bangs past me and stomps down the hall and slams the bedroom door behind her. I'm thinking, what's to understand? You're totally nuts!

I'm standing there alone in the bathroom. The place looks like a tornado hit, there's little bottles and vials and tubes all over, with that little pink baby-positive stick lying right in the middle like the eye of the hurricane, the evil eye, more like, still and pink and sticking its tongue out at me. Ha. You lost. You fucked up. I'm thinking, what happened? I thought only fat girls didn't know what they were doing. My kid's a beauty, gorgeous, skinny, tall, why the hell didn't she stand up for herself? How could she let this happen? She's got no goddam spine!

Then I'm back to the time when she was just two years old, the first time I saw her throw

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a tantrum. It was in the kitchen, over a purple popsicle. I was so surprised at the force inside her little body. She stamped her bare feet on the kitchen floor and balled up her fists and bared her tiny white teeth at me, and when I said, No, and shut the refrigerator door with the toe of my shoe she looked up into my face and squinted, she wasn't three feet tall, and her mouth got tiny like the...head of a nail, and I knew I had someone to contend with then.

So I go into the bedroom, sit down on the edge of the bed and pat her on the back. Stacey, sweets, hey, hey, it's alright. You gotta be strong and make your own choice, but whatever decision you want to make, I'm behind you, okay? We'll do whatever you choose. She stops sniffing. She breathes in and out. I say, So, listen, uh.. .have you talked to the guy about this yet? And she says, nasty, No, Ma, God. Boys don't like girls who boss them around.

[A flashbulb pops and RENNIE *is propelled into center.]*

RENNIE: The first picture of me is at my first birthday party. In this one I am screaming with laughter and holding my hands up to show the camera that I am covered with chocolate cake. My face is smeared with it, it is all over the front of my pretty pink dress. Apparently I was quite verbally advanced, and my parents were showing me off when my uncle Jake said, Oh yeah? How smart is she? She's a genius, says my mother, she understands everything. Try it. She'll do anything you say.
So... Rennie, says my uncle Jake, smush that chocolate cake all over your face, sweetheart. Will you do that for me? And I did it of course because I was just that smart and I ruined my dress and they took a picture of me humiliating myself when I was twelve months old.

[Flashbulb pops.]

This one is my mother's favorite. It's of her and me on one of our mother-daughter days, we're on the steps of the Met looking very close and what you don't see is Mother

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boring her knuckles into the small of my back saying Straighten up, sweetheart, it lengthens your neck. Now glow, come on, glow. We want this one to glow.

For awhile there is an absence of photos - when tummies are no longer little-girl cute. Mother hides me at family gatherings and I seem always to end up behind pieces of furniture. So we have no extant record of the long years of wanting, of wanting and wanting and being denied. Reaching for bread and peanut butter and having Slimfast thrust into my tWelve-yearold fist. Mother says No, I am putting my foot down. She is putting her foot down, I see, and I see that to want and demand things is bad.

And when I finally want nothing, nothing at all, when I finally want so little I can barely get up in the morning, my head feels like a ten ton brick on my shoulders, my knees buckle walking from class to class, when I want so little the gentlest sounds scrape my ears and my skin is sore and my hair falls out, finally my mother pulls me out from behind the chaise longue and says This is my daughter Rennie! This is my wonderful, beautiful daughter. Out comes the camera!

[Flashbulb pops.]

The pictures reappear. All the while Mother says Sweetheart, you're beautiful. You really do glow.

[Flashbulb pops.]

In this one I am standing outside my own house, in a hideous dress I do not recall choosing, it is blue and it feels like a garbage bag next to my skin. I am wearing a floppy white orchid on my wrist and man, am I glowing. I am really fucking glowing. My smile is about this wide on my face though I don't know what I am smiling about because Andrew Marino has his hand on my back. We haven't even left the house yet, my mother is still snapping pictures and there he is, slinking his hand up my dress. Later we are in the dark and he is breathing so hard he is fogging the windshield and I say to him Andrew. No. No. And he says to me Rennie, you're beautiful. Please

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Rennie please, will you do it for me? I am saying, No, I am saying, Stop, but he does not hear me, I am not loud enough. I am so - weak. I am just...too...weak.

[Flashbulb pops.]

In this one my mother is getting remarried. She is a vision in indigo organdy, she looks half her age, her husband's in real estate. But heavens, where's Rennie? Rennie's not in this one. Rennie is wearing an attractive off-white linen pants suit, but she is not in her place at her mother's side because she is in the parish hall kitchen, devouring the three-foot-tall wedding cake meant to serve one hundred and eighty guests. It was just so pristine, floating there, with no one to guard it, no one to witness...1 ate and I ate and I ate it all up until there wasn't one crumb left, not a single frosted rosette, and I held that whole cake inside my body, I had it all to myself. And then I threw it all up on the kitchen floor and I walked out the back door into the night.

[Lights shift, up on CEL in her corner. During the course of the monologue she moves up center and then progressively further downstage.]

CEL: It starts with a girl maybe six maybe seven, looking down at herself seeing how - horrible she was! How gross like a monster. She didn't look anything like the other kids from 4-H, they were all skinny as rats from dragging goats through the mud and bending over fields in the blazing hot sun. In summer all kids' legs were scabby - but nobody had marks on them like I did, like Cel, Cel had some scars.

The first one came when I was six. I had split open my knee climbing through barbed wire and mama drove me to the hospital to get the thing stitched up with ugly dark thread, that's how deep it was. But I took those stitches out with scissors when I got home. I told my mama they came out in the bath but I could tell by the way she looked at me sidewise frying the eggs that she didn't believe it. All that summer I

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worked on my knee and by the time Labor Day rolled around my leg looked like it had been caught in a thresher, maybe.

After that she just seemed to find them, Cel, these cuts in her skin, these holes. They seemed to pop up without her even noticing. Some she put in there herself with the kitchen knives for killing the chickens or shears for the garden or the awl daddy used for punching holes in saddles.

Mama didn't know what to do with her girl. At first she didn't say anything, just folded her arms like so across her chest. What's happened to the backs of your feet she asked. You're picking those cuts of yours apart aren't you? What are you doing to yourself Celie? Why do you want to do such a thing toyourself? So she started buying extra boxes of bandaids and leaving them about the house in places she thought I might be likely to come across them. But I wanted to - take myself completely apart. I had dreams of my body parts spread out in the yard for everyone even the neighbors to see.

All the way through high school I did it at night when no one was looking. After my shower, when the skin was still soft. It was my thing to know. Then one day my husband found me on the floor of the bathroom, busted in without knocking...After that he kept watching me, keeping track where I went. I tried to lay still. I forgot things.. .left them to burn on the stove. My husband paced around and slammed the door on his way out. He accused me of letting the heat out in winter, letting animals in, stray cats and birds.

So I needed a final solution. Get rid of all of the flesh at once. I was poking a roaster chicken full of cloves getting ready for Sunday dinner and I went to light the broiler with a hard wooden match. Then it came to me. My body - I wanted to light it on fire. Hear the fat sizzle into smoke. With all the fat gone I could dance - more than that, I could run and jump and fly maybe even, just me and my bones

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running naked through the meadows feeling the breeze. It seemed so obvious - why hadn't I thought of this before? I struck one of the matches, stroked it smooth across the rough edge of the box and I could feel the flame sparking and growing and swallowing the match head. I held it in front of my face. It flickered in my own breath. My thighs would go up first I thought then the rest of me would catch on quick. I lifted my leg and dropped the match onto my pants. For a moment-nothing, then - warm hot my leg started to jump - my skin was on fire. I screamed without meaning to Oh my God. I reeled around to face the counter my hands out in front of me reaching - desperate - something anything. Towel potholder glass of water.. . In my mind I heard Miss Moser from in front of the black board - stop, drop and roll, she said, if you ever catch fire just stop, drop and... Later I went to the phone to call 911, shivering, numb. I caught fire, I said calmly into the phone. I was cooking a chicken. It escaped.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Madeline George
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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier – DI - Female
2005 National Qualifier – DI - Female
2007 National Qualifier– DI – Female
2009 National Qualifier – DI - Female
IL State Qualifier– DI - Female
S. Dakota State Finalist– DI - Female